particularity of this family environment, overseen by Bhagat Singh's grandfather Arjun Singh', [6] that is chiefly responsible for the young man's flowering into a towering national leader who rivalled Gandhi. Moffat, however, rejects this implication for three reasons, arguing that if Bhagat Singh grew up to be great, it was because he defined himself in opposition to his family.

First, there was his 'his rejection of arrangements made for his marriage in 1923: a charged decision which led the young man to run away to Cawnpore'. However, whilst this may have been a rejection of marriage, what it was not was a repudiation of his family values. Bhagat Singh was sixteen years old then, and his grandmother, impatient in seeing her grandson still a bachelor, made haste to arrange for a match for him. Bhagat Singh tried in vain to dissuade her from this course of action. Frustrated, he left Lahore for Kanpur, where he met up with a noted Congress leader, Ganesh Shankar Vidyarthi, and began to edit the newspaper *Pratap* in Hindi. It turned out to be a fateful step, as it was there that he met three of the twenty-four named insurgents in the Lahore Conspiracy Case, namely, B.K. Dutt, Shiv Kumar Verma, and Bejoy Kumar Sinha. On his way to Kanpur, he left behind a letter for his father humbly requesting that, 'I hope you will be magnanimous and forgive me' but that 'my life has been dedicated to the cause of attaining freedom for Hindustan' and that 'worldly desires and comfort hold no attraction for me'. His father would hardly have been in a position to argue. In Hinduism, a rite of passage that starts the period of formal education for a young boy is when he receives a sacred thread in a formal ritual, and Bhagat Singh lost no time in reminding his father when as a child his grandfather 'had announced that by the time of my *yagyopavit* ceremony that I would be dedicated to the service of my nation'. [7] In so writing, rather than disowning his family, Bhagat connects himself with its very essence.

Second, it is said that he abandoned religion altogether, which was not an insignificant matter given 'his father's Hindu reformist roots in the Arya Samaj and his mother's Sikhism', and he did so to such an extent that he even set his iconoclasm out 'in the 1931 essay "*Why I am an Atheist*"'.